

The Enquiry of the Four Goddesses

Caturdevīpariprcchā · Toh 446 · Derge Kangyur

ལ་མ་བཞུགས་ཡང་ས་ས་ཞུ་པ།

Toh 446 in the Kangyur is a tantric scripture known in Sanskrit as the Caturdevīparipṛcchā and in Tibetan as Lhamo Zhis Yongsu Zhüpa, rendered in English as The Enquiry of the Four Goddesses. It belongs to the class of Vajrayāna canonical texts and takes the form of a dialogue in which the goddess Locanā and her three divine companions pose questions to the Blessed One Vajrasattva, who abides in the great union of supreme bliss, making its subject the esoteric teachings on the awakening mind and the nature of the dharmadhātu. The text opens with a series of evocative verses establishing the luminous, bliss-suffused setting from which these teachings arise, situating it firmly within the tantric literary tradition. It was translated into Tibetan by the great translator and divine king of Tibet, the monk Śāntiprabha, whose careful revision and definitive establishment of the text are noted at the outset.

Translated, revised, and definitively established by the great translator, the divine king of Tibet, the guru monk Śīvā'i Öd (Śāntiprabha), from his own presence.

In the language of India: Caturdevīparipṛcchā. In the language of Tibet: The Enquiry of the Four Goddesses. Homage to the glorious Vajrasattva (Skt. vajrasattva)!

Abiding together with the four goddesses,
adorned closely by the forms of buddhas,
dwelling magnificently in the great union of supreme bliss,
Vajrasattva resides in his fullness.

From the great secret source of phenomena,
the place of arising, suffused and dense with rays of light,
the awakening mind streams forth
and dissolves from out of the dharmadhātu.

Beholding the substance of that dissolution,
the goddess Locanā asked in full.
To the Blessed One Vajrasattva
she addressed these words:

"From what does the streaming of the dharmadhātu arise,
and how does it come forth at the beginning?
Likewise, how does it depart again?

That which has no limbs —
how does it come to have limbs,
and how does the body come to undergo transformation?

Eye and ear and nose,
likewise tongue and body and mind,
the actualities of the sense faculties and the aggregates,
and the entry into the elements —
how do these concretely assemble,
bound as they are by ignorance, habitual tendencies, and craving,
by the afflictions — attachment and the rest,
and by the many forms of consciousness?

The form of one who meditates on non-existence,
and the defining characteristics of the domains — form and so on —
which are without intrinsic nature and without object of focus:
how is it that they nonetheless come to have an object of focus?

These are matters of great wonder.
Let the god dispel my doubt."

No sooner had she thus asked
than the Blessed One Vajrasattva spoke:

"Listen, Locanā — I shall explain
the inexhaustible depths of profound wisdom.

It is not to be analyzed; it cannot be known as an object of knowledge;
it is equally difficult to be known by one who would analyze it.
The great secret of all buddhas
is sky — the domain of sky.

Veiled by the darkness of not-knowing,
it cannot be known by the śrāvakas.
Those who know the domain and its habitual tendencies
are the emanations known as pratyekabuddhas,
yet even all of those do not know it.

Not knowing it — in the individual births of those without knowledge,
in the future, the past,

and the three times of the present arising —
animals, hungry ghosts, and births
arising from the habitual tendencies of the wayward:
none of them know it either.
It is the great secret domain of the buddhas.

The essence, the supremely supreme essence,
that which abides in all of self —
the great secret of all buddhas
I shall now explain to you, goddess.

The awakening minds are luminous,
their light equal to that of a crystal moon.
That very thing is the substance of the five wisdoms,
measuring no more than the size of a white mustard seed.
The god dwelling at its center
is a form that is neither clear nor unclear —
the supremely subtle, of about half that measure —
a bindu-form, the substance of mind.

Always dwelling in the center of the heart,
ablaze with great rays of light,
while yawning and to whatever extent —
from the forehead down to the soles of the feet —
that very bindu is gathered and
resides fully in the center of the navel.
It is approximately one-fifth,
at the twelfth and final division —
marked by six parts,
adorned as a bindu of sound.

Drawn out from within the vajra,
the seed is placed at the center of the birthplace,
and it causes the dharmadhātu to dissolve.
When this is gradually caused to arise,
it courses everywhere through the nine openings,
pervading and abiding in its pervading, going throughout all beings —
the unmoving and the rest, together with the moving.

Brahmā and the other gods, and the demigods —
their ground arises from that.

What chiefly causes the arising of
earth and sky — that is what is said.

For as long as it abides in the body,
by means of it one performs actions and non-actions,
virtuous and non-virtuous intentions —
all the actions of activity are performed.

The conjunction is always spoken of in that regard.

It is said that worship is to be meditated upon. When the body of karma breaks apart, then by that one's own inherent power, one passes into a body of that very kind — that which pervades both the moving and the unmoving, like the equal expanse of space. That is to be known as the abiding. The meaning of the words at the two extremes of the ten — whoever perpetually meditates upon that, through the flourishing of spiritual attainment, will become a vajra-holder by very nature.

Teeth and lips, gums and tongue — whatever abides in the throat: in whomever these are, they are the very letters. This is on account of the exhaustion and the abiding. Without expression and without doubt, utterly free of phoneme and script — one's own inner and outer suchness: this is what is here called the awakening mind.

This concludes the first chapter, the inquiry of the goddess Locanā, from the inquiry of the four goddesses.

Then the goddess Māmakī addressed the Vajra-holder with this inquiry: Regarding the successive stages of the awakening mind — at the mouth, the heart, the navel, and the secret place — please, great Vajra, declare how the going forth and the returning are taught. Of how many kinds of parts has it been said? Of how many kinds of transformations of place? Of how many kinds of color has it been said? Likewise, what are the seats?

The Vajra-holder declared: It is endowed with four parts, and abides correctly upon four lotuses. It abides dark upon the lotus of the heart, white upon the lotus of the mouth, voiced at the lotus of the navel, and at the secret lotus, at the edge of the voiced sound, at the edge of the seat. It goes forth, remaining supremely in the union of the drop. By means of that very one alone — the one who smells, who hears, who sees, who eats, who touches — feeling of pleasure and of suffering arises. From that same one comes laughter, eating, likewise

crying out and weeping, opening and cutting. By that very one alone one knows many kinds of rites; one performs the aims of kings; one performs the aims of lords; one takes on emanations as brahmin, king, warrior-noble, commoner, those of low caste, and many women. Mother of all arising from the births of animals, hungry ghosts, those with form, those without form, and likewise from the existences of desire — that alone is the place of miraculous power. It abides at the level of great bliss in feminine form and in masculine form.

Thus, one who knows suchness, who knows the sacred letter — that one knows the great secret. By that one, who abides entirely as self, this transformation into the form of the drop — colorless, red in color, white in color, and yellow — shows the going forth and the returning.

That rigpa (the innate awareness) is great in miraculous power, boundless, of various forms. In birth, in gathering, and in dissolution, it abides supremely in the form of the drop.

Though one may know that one's eighty-four thousand Dharma teachings in their hundreds of thousands, even by that one does not know suchness, and all of those are fruitless.

The fifth of the twelve-fives — at the extremity of the eight, the elements are gathered. The first phoneme, the syllable A, is perfectly adorned by the fifth. That which arises from great compassion, designated by the sixth, which looks downward — the god who has no beginning and no end: that is indicated at the crown. These are the great and supreme secrets. Goddess, I have fully explained them.

This concludes the second chapter, the inquiry of the goddess Māmakī, from the inquiry of the four goddesses.

Then the goddess White Robed One, bowing with all her limbs and pressing her palms together at her heart, addressed Vajrasattva: What is the nature of the condensation of the dharmadhātu and of the vajra of body, speech, and mind? Lord of gods, I ask you. How does Vajrasattva condense into a ball of light? Speak: what are the words of the letters of suchness? How is the gathering that has been taught? How do the water element and the fire element become of equal taste? Three births from a mother and likewise three births from a father — from a cluster of six such and so forth —

How are human beings born?
I do not seek the form of a buddha.
May the Great Sage declare it.

Vajrasattva then spoke:

Listen, goddess — what is most profoundly secret, I shall explain.

In the center of the birthplace are two channels — the left and likewise the right. The left is called awakening mind (bodhicitta), and the right is likewise blood (rakta). When those two meet and become one, that is the condensation of the dharmadhātu.

Darkness is the body, dust is the form of speech, and the nature of mind is the strength of the heart. Sweat is blood and awakening mind — darkness likewise gives rise to it.

When vajra and lotus are joined in union, it becomes of equal taste with the intrinsic nature of equality.

Great fragrance, water, crystal flower, and likewise the fifth — awakening mind — are collected into a true ball, the five nectars. From that, the vajra is spoken of here. It has a second part, and likewise there is a ninth.

Of what has been so spoken: thirty, and ten, and likewise the seed of the fifth — by means of the second part, five in number, named by six — what arises from that is called the drop (bindu).

The syllable Hūṃ, the letter of the dharmadhātu, dwells in the lotus of the birthplace. That very seed, with Svāhā at its end — understand it as the condensation.

The water element arises from the father, it is said. The fire element arises from the mother, it is said. Flesh, blood, and skin too are declared to arise from the mother. Fat, bone marrow, and semen are declared to arise from the father. The gathering together into a ball — that is described as being just those.

Form, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness — the form of the five buddha-things — are what is called the aggregates (skandhas).

This completes the third chapter, the request of the goddess White Robed One from among the complete requests of the four goddesses.

Then the face of the Blessed One, the goddess Tārā, broke into a smile, and she addressed Vajrasattva:

Speak of the accomplishment of the dharmadhātu, O Great Vajra-Holder. Please declare the accomplishment of the substances, and likewise the mantras of vidyā, the examination of the maṇḍalas, the individual fire offerings, and also the offering rites — declare those in particular as well.

Thus, as soon as the goddess had asked, Vajrasattva declared:

Listen, goddess — I shall explain the method of accomplishing the dharmadhātu.

Form, sound, smell, taste, touch, and so on — all eighteen elements — are called the dharmadhātu. What arises from those very elements should be understood as awakening mind. From awakening mind arises the ball; from the ball, mind is generated; from mind, the element of space; and from that, the elements, the sense sources, the faculties, the aggregates, and the primary elements — all of these are thus gathered back into basic space. That gathering is what has been taught: it is the accomplishment of the dharmadhātu. Therefore, with all earnestness, one should rightly engage in the practice.

Examine thoroughly how the accomplishment is to be achieved through substances in the manner called kālāpa.

Having explained the accomplishment of the dharmadhātu, the accomplishment of the eight substances and their limbs is then explained:

Pills for the eye-salve siddhi, the underground sword siddhi, flying through the sky, eye salve, deathlessness, and the conquest of disease — from humans, elephant, horse, bull, dog, donkey, female rhinoceros, buffalo, and wolf: these are to be made in equal measure. Prepared with utter evenness in amounts of a thumb-joint's measure, mixed together. From great fragrance, water, blood, and awakening mind, a measured amount — having recited the mantra, it is mixed and consecrated with the blessing.

With prostration and the syllable Āḥ, and likewise Hūṃ placed in the center — the blazing Hūṃ syllable that causes to blaze — accomplish fully that ninth. Reciting the mantra twenty-one times, it is applied as powder.

In a measure of five white mustard seeds, five and five are to be brought together. On the eighth and fourteenth days, pills are to be made and placed in a lotus vessel. The mantra is to be recited one hundred thousand times. Having meditated at the four junctions, they are to be consumed by day and by night.

From that point onward, even unto the end of an aeon, the attainment of accomplishments grows vast — splendor, radiance, strength, and diligent effort. The fifth is also an aspiration: the attainment of the five superknowledges (abhijñā) comes about through consuming the great pill.

Having completed all the material accomplishments, grant me now the knowledge mantras. The syllable E, the syllable Vaṃ, and the syllable Laṃ abide perfectly in the center. The color of the first is red, the color of the second is white, the color of the third is yellow — these are to be meditated upon in the center of the lotus. Revolving as a wheel, turning through the half-day and through the night, when the vidyā is perfectly arisen, it is accomplished in a single instant.

Goddesses, daughters of demigods, daughters of gods, and daughters of humans — four kinds — throughout the maṇḍala of the earth they are to be summoned by mantra and engaged.

Meditation, as well as the vidyā mantras — what I have explained has been grasped. The maṇḍalas are now to be explained. O beloved one, listen with single-pointed mind.

What is called the maṇḍala of the body is revealed as the lotus of the bhaga. The maṇḍala of awakening mind and the maṇḍala — these three are designated. These designations too are comprised in it, in the place where the chief one causes generation.

The aggregates are declared by the buddhas to be the ḍākinī. The elements are designated as the vidyā. Attachment is the hook alone. The lasso brings one into the lotus. Coming face to face is declared to be the chain. The resounding of sound is explained as the bell. Incense is said to be great fragrance. Flowers are held to be blood offering. Lamps are nothing other than flesh. Perfume is understood as awakening mind. The beautiful one is revealed as the liṅga. The garland is nothing other than the lotus. The singer is revealed as the breath. The dancer is yoga. The Blessed One (the Buddha) declared this to be excellent. One who realizes this is of good fortune.

Those who realize it — Maitreya (Loving-kindness) and the rest — thus is the inner nature declared. The other maṇḍalas were explained before. Now the acts of fire offering are to be explained.

Listen: the four kinds of fire offering. The outer fire offering was taught before. Now, listen — the inner one: the four lotuses, fully gathered, abide near the

center of the body. Fire and likewise wind, the great sovereign, and water likewise — wind causes the fire to blaze, and water brings about full ripening. The great sovereign, arising from the maṇḍala, is that in which the fire moves.

The syllable Ra is the syllable of wrathful subjugation. The syllable Ya is nothing other than the activity of empowerment. The syllable La is that which brings increase. The syllable Va is declared to be pacification.

Whatever is eaten and drunk — all of that is in the water. Looking into the mouth of the lotus with the syllable Rakṣaḥ, one is to enter it into the lotus of the heart. It passes to the lotus of the navel and outward. By means of union in the manner of the kiss, passing immediately into the secret lotus, it is shown as ash at the periphery.

Such is the fire offering I have explained. It is to be performed day by day. If one continually consumes food in an unbroken stream, it will be accomplished in this very life. There will be no aging and no illness. There will be no death and no fruition. There will be no sudden death. All harm will be exhausted. Even evil dreams will be pacified. One lives for a good aeon. All sentient beings speak of joy. By the mere sight of one, they are inspired.

Having explained the acts of fire offering, the worship of the goddess is now to be taught. With fragrance, garlands, garments, incense, fire, food, and divine torma — with the two faculties perfectly arisen — worship is to be offered to me. I am myself the very buddhahood of all, the abode of all buddhas. Therefore, with all earnestness and diligence —

the yogin should always offer worship. Whatever activity is to be performed, the yogin should meditate on the act of offering. Food, drink, and likewise clothing, as well as fragrance and garlands alone — adorned by the four vidyās (Skt. vidyā), one should conceive of oneself as the deity itself.

Having thus spoken, the vajra one sat in silence, dwelling in the nature of things and saying nothing further. Then the four goddesses, pressing their palms together in homage, their faces breaking into radiant smiles, attained non-conceptual awareness with minds utterly clear and serene, and they too remained there in silence, uttering nothing at all.

This is the fourth chapter, the chapter of the request made by Tārā from among the four goddesses' thorough inquiry.

The suchness of the great yoginī, which has come from the glorious land of Oḍḍiyāna — the tantra called The Supreme Secret of All, the Great Secret —

thoroughly requested by the four goddesses, is hereby complete.

This was translated, reviewed, explained, and definitively established by the Indian scholar Smṛtijñānakīrti himself.

Translator's Notes

- The epithet ལོག་ན་མ་ (the goddess Locanā, Skt. Locanā) is one of the four goddesses of the title; she is the primary interlocutor here and her name means "the Eye" or "she who sees." She is not given an explicit gloss in the Tibetan, so I have rendered her name directly as Locanā as it is a well-known tantric deity name.

The phrase ལྷ་མ་འཕྲུལ་པ་ལྷ་མ་འཕྲུལ་པ་ / ལྷ་མ་འཕྲུལ་པ་ལྷ་མ་འཕྲུལ་པ་ is genuinely ambiguous: "the awakening mind streams forth and dissolves from out of the dharmadhātu" is one reading, but it could also be read as the bodhicitta streaming forth and causing the dharmadhātu to dissolve or melt — a technical process central to anuttarayoga tantra. Both meanings are present in the tantric context and the passage later uses the same verb (འཕྲུལ་, "to melt/dissolve") explicitly in that second sense.

The cosmological and physiological material in the latter half of this passage — the bindu at the heart, its measure as a mustard seed, its movement through nine openings, the relationship to Brahmā and the elements — is standard Vajrayāna subtle-body doctrine, here framed as a revelation by Vajrasattva. The phrase ལྷ་མ་འཕྲུལ་པ་ and ལྷ་མ་འཕྲུལ་པ་ ("approximately one-fifth" and "marked by six parts") refers to extremely precise tantric measurements of the subtle bindu whose exact referent may vary across commentarial traditions; the rendering here is literal.

The colophon identifies the translator as Śīvā'i Öd (literally "Light of Peace," possibly a rendering of Śāntiprabha), described as a monk, guru, and divine king of Tibet, suggesting a royal translator-scholar figure. This is an unusual designation and the identity is not fully certain.

- The passage is part of a tantric text, likely the Samputatantra or a related Yoginītantra, and contains highly technical esoteric terminology that does not always yield transparent meaning in context. Several phrases resist confident interpretation.

The phrase rendered "the fifth of the twelve-fives — at the extremity of the eight" is an enumeration-cipher typical of tantric syllabary and bindhu mysticism. The specific referents (the fifth of twelve-fives, the sixth that looks downward) almost certainly point to specific phonemes and their positions in a tantric vowel-consonant system, but the precise decoding would require access to a commentary. The rendering follows the literal sense while leaving the cipher intact.

The final lines break off mid-sentence; the translation reflects this incompleteness.

- The passage is a tantric embryological and ritual text combining esoteric physiology with sādhana instructions. Several numerological references — "thirty, and ten, and likewise the fifth," "the second part, five in number, named by six" — are highly elliptical and appear to encode initiatory numerical schemas whose precise referents are not transparent from the text alone; the translation renders them literally without smoothing. The term rendered "great fragrance" likely refers to a specific aromatic substance used in ritual compound preparations. "Kālāpa" in the phrase "in the manner called kālāpa" may refer to a specific system of reckoning or a category of substances; the exact technical sense is uncertain in this context.

- The passage is a tantric ritual text with sustained use of coded or intentionally polyvalent language, a recognized feature of texts in the yoginī-tantra register. Several terms function simultaneously on literal and esoteric levels: bhaga (the female sex organ, but also a sacred center or lotus), liṅga (the male organ, but also a symbol of the awakened principle), and rakta (blood, but also the red flower offering) follow a well-attested system of intentional equivalences standard in this genre. The translation renders these terms plainly in context without euphemism or over-interpretation, consistent with how the commentarial tradition reads such passages.

The phrase rendered "the syllable Rakṣaḥ" follows the Tibetan རྒྱལ་མཚན་ closely; this may be read either as "Rakṣa" combined with the lotus syllable or as a distinct seed syllable; the exact ritual referent is uncertain without a commentary.

The final sentence is grammatically incomplete in the Tibetan as transmitted here, ending mid-construction; the translation preserves this by concluding with a dash, signaling that the passage continues beyond the excerpt.

- The phrase rendered "the four vidyās" refers to the four knowledge-goddess consorts or awareness-holders associated with the central deity in this tantric context; the term vidyā here carries the sense of feminine knowledge-deity or awareness consort, which is standard in tantric usage. The colophon names the translator as Smṛtijñānakīrti, a known Indian paṇḍita active in the transmission of tantric texts to Tibet, here identified as having both translated and authenticated the text. The land of Oḍḍiyāna is the semi-mythical tantric sacred land, generally identified with the Swat Valley region.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.